

without buying a drink every half-hour. You can get a ginger ale instead of a \$14 cocktail. Don't be embarrassed if you're the only one.) You can bring snacks to the park! You can go to a free museum! You can go for a walk or bike ride! My girlfriend and I like to shoot hoops at the outdoor court in our neighborhood. So many activities are free!

ENVELOPE MONEY. The Envelope Budget, according to [TheBalance.com](https://www.thebalance.com), requires you to take a chunk of money out in cash and separate it into envelopes marked for what it's going to be spent on. "When you run out of money in that category, you stop spending," the article said. "In order to make this work, you cannot use your debit card for the categories that you have envelopes for." This method seems super hard to me, but if you can swing it, I bow to you.

50/30/20. The 50/30/20 budget suggests that "needs" get 50 percent of your income, "wants" get 30 percent, and 20 percent goes into savings, retirement, and debt repayment. This is a good benchmark if you don't want to track every dollar of every category, but it's not necessarily realistic if you live in a super high-rent place where that alone could be half your income, even with roommates. What about other needs like bills or food? It doesn't leave much room.

CATEGORY 5. This budget breaks your income into five parts. For housing, you can spend up to 35 percent of your income. For transportation, you should spend no more than 15 percent of your income. For other living expenses (such as groceries, utilities, and wants), you can spend up to 25 percent of your income. For savings, you should set aside 10 percent each month. And for debt payoff, 15 percent of your income, according to the Balance.

You can also use specific budgeting apps, like the second app I downloaded at my girlfriend's behest, called "You Need A Budget." This app works for me because my income is different every month. It allows me to see how much I spend every month so I can plan for expenses instead of being surprised by every